Cold weather dog walk checklist.

A quick checklist for winter walks, based on public guidance from veterinary schools and the AVMA. There is no single number that is too cold for every dog, so use it to check your own dog.

Before you head out

- [ ] Know your dog's tolerance: puppies, older dogs, small dogs and short-haired dogs feel the cold more.[3, 4]
- [ ] Check the temperature. Purdue veterinarians say puppies and short-haired pets should not stay outdoors below 40°F (about 4°C), so keep their time outside short.[2]
- [ ] Consider a sweater or dog coat, especially for smaller dogs, short coats or a dog bothered by the cold.[2, 4]
- [ ] Consider booties, and make sure they fit.[1, 4]
- [ ] Consider keeping the hair between the paw pads short and applying paw balm before each walk.[3]

On the walk

- [ ] Keep the walk short when it is very cold.[3, 4]
- [ ] Watch for shivering, slowing down, anxiety or lifting paws off the ground, and head back inside if you see them.[3, 4]
- [ ] Check longer-haired dogs' feet for ice and snow.[3]
- [ ] Stay away from frozen ponds, lakes and streams.[4]

When you get home

- [ ] Wipe or wash your dog's feet, legs and belly to remove de-icing products, antifreeze and other chemicals. Salt and de-icer can hurt paw pads.[2, 4]
- [ ] Check the paws for signs of irritation or injury.[4]
- [ ] Store antifreeze out of reach and clean up spills right away.[3]

> **Talk to your vet.** If you suspect hypothermia or frostbite, or notice concerning signs of a cold-related injury, call your vet right away. Your vet can also advise on coats and paw care for your dog.

Want the reasons behind each item? Read How cold is too cold for dogs?.

Sources.

1. Washington State University College of Veterinary Medicine, Veterinary Teaching Hospital. When is it too cold for your pet? 2025.
2. Nickel A, Purdue News Service. If you think they’re warm enough, wear a thin jacket and spend 10 minutes outside with your pet. Purdue University news release, 2019.
3. Cornell University College of Veterinary Medicine. Keeping your furry friends safe during winter weather. 2021.
4. American Veterinary Medical Association. Cold weather animal safety. AVMA.